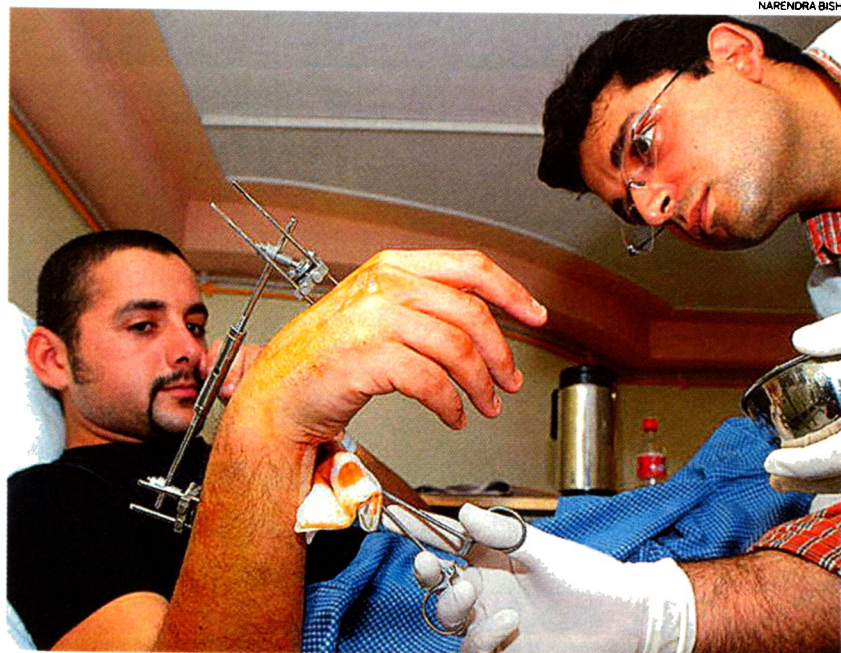


Reddy, who has been with AIIMS since 1974, first as a student and finally as the head of cardiology. The experience of people "queuing up from 6 a.m. for an OPD at 2 p.m." has been routine for him. "The idea of 'medical care' is benchmarked partly by peers in the profession and partly by the patient," he says. "Treatment quality forms a key component. At AIIMS, you may have to wait long to access a doctor, but you end up getting the best possible treatment." But the human interface with a hospital in India often lacks sensitivity and compassion, he adds. "A study like this sends out a crucial signal that a hospital must not only be care-giving, but a caring facility which is hospitable."



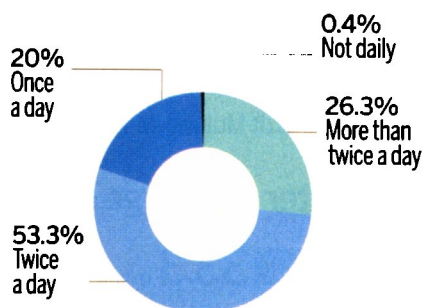
NARENDRA BISHT

The lounge in front of Trehan's chamber fills up with patients recovering from surgery at a certain point during the day. And it's always a poignant moment. As the doctor moves about, asking a question here and checking a dressing there, the fragile men and women on wheel chairs reach out—touching, stroking, kissing his hands—looking wonderingly up at his face. In medicine, the patient's trust in a doctor's "superior power" is an important part of the therapeutic effectiveness. And more than pristine degrees, the doctor's attention span and willingness to listen to patients matter. In the VOICE study, patients expressed satisfaction with doctors not so much in clinical terms but more for their "courtesy" and for "listening, explaining and visiting when required". Surprisingly, the same doctors that patients approved of scored lowest when "communicating the expected charges" to patients (for instance, Apollo, Chennai and Manipal, Bangalore).

Wockhardt Superspeciality on Cunningham Road in Bangalore, surpassed on several counts: it's most re-

## STAYING IN

How often did the doctors visit you?



## trust in doctor top 5

1. Apollo Hospital, Chennai
2. Wockhardt Cunningham, Bangalore
3. Manipal Hospital, Bangalore
4. Care Banjara, Hyderabad
5. Sri Ramachandra Med Col, Chennai

ferred by other doctors, top in overall trust in diagnostics, second in "trust on doctors", one of the top five in overall patient satisfaction, to name a few. What's their secret of success? To CEO Vishal Bali, it's the "stringent credentialing process" the group follows when it comes to recruitment of medical professionals. "Most of our consultants have either studied or worked extensively in

some of the world's most renowned healthcare institutions," he says. The hospital also has a proactive approach in its relationship with doctors: "We ensure that their every need—technology or human resource—is met."

Yet Wockhardt doesn't satisfy its patients in one vital category: billing and charges, the weakest link in the patient-satisfaction index for all su-

